# The 2026 midterms swung toward Democrats.

## Why?

People have lots of ideas. I tested three of them with public data. Each page checks one clue.

**Swipe to follow along →**

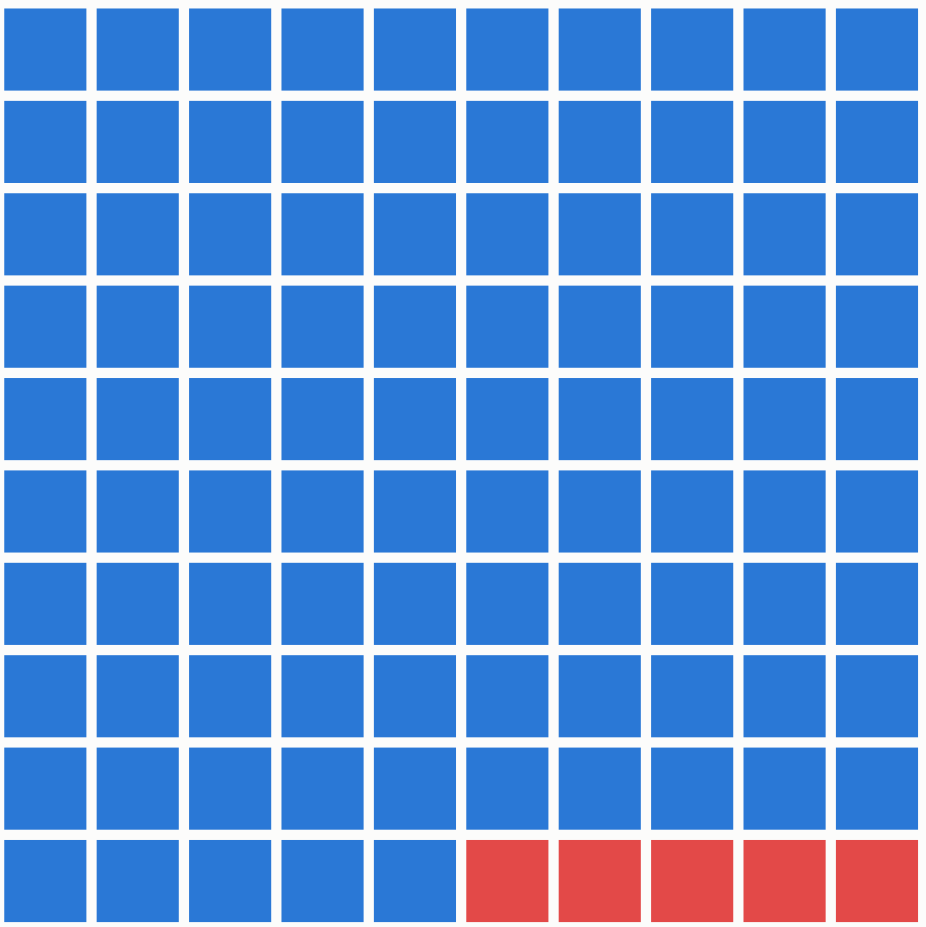
CLUE TRACKER

| ? More people voting | ? More money | ? Voters changed |
| --- | --- | --- |
| Not tested yet | Not tested yet | Not tested yet |

By Bhrett Boggs. Results are unofficial, as of Nov. 6, 2026.

# First, what happened? 95 of every 100 counties moved toward Democrats.

Compared with how the same county voted for president in 2024.



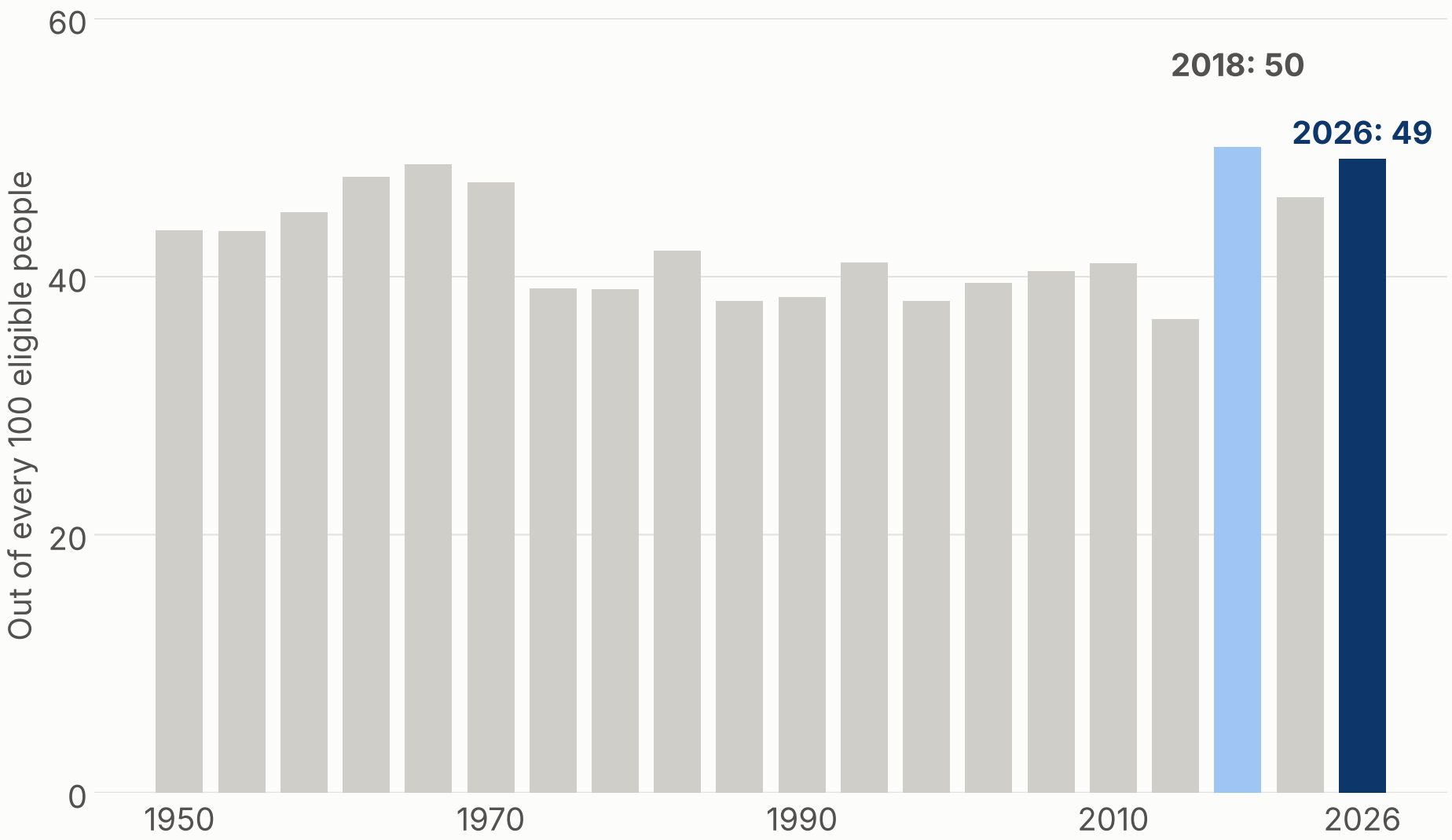

**That is a lot. So what caused it? Let's test three ideas.**

2,584 counties in 42 states with a Senate or governor race between a Democrat and a Republican.
The 2026 races are for Senate or governor, not president, so some of the move is just different races.

# Idea 1: More people voted.

49 out of every 100 eligible people voted.

That's the 2nd most for a midterm in over 100 years.




**High turnout is a common guess for a big swing.**

**But did it actually cause it? Next page.**

CLUE TRACKER

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Not tested yet

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Not tested yet

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Not tested yet

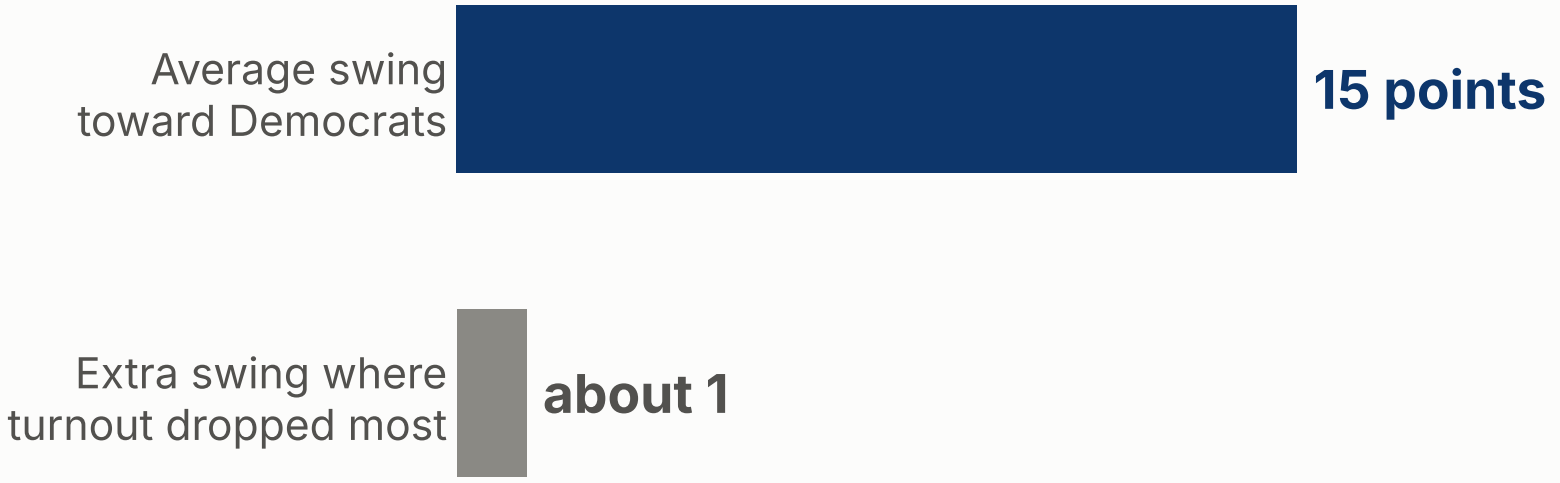
Midterm turnout of eligible citizens. 2026 is an early estimate.

Data: Michael McDonald, UF Election Lab.

# Turnout test: only a small part.

I compared counties inside the same state.

Where fewer people showed up, the swing was only about 1 point bigger. The total swing was about 15.




What's a point? If one side wins 55 to 45, they lead by 10 points.

A swing of 15 means the lead moved 15 points toward Democrats.

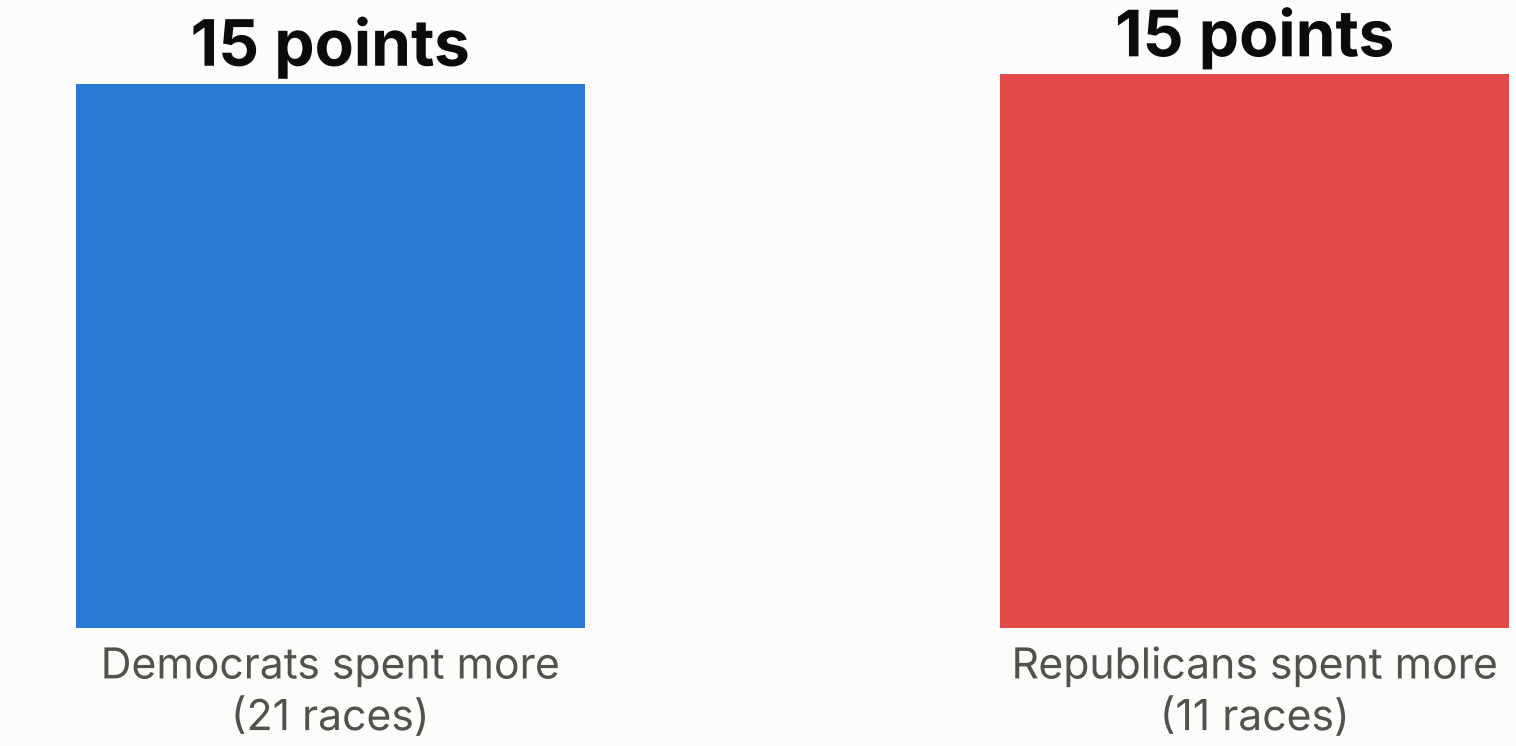
CLUE TRACKER

- × **More people voting** — Only a small part
- ? **More money** — Not tested yet
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673 counties at 95%+ counted. "Turnout dropped most" = the fifth of counties in each state with the biggest drop in votes since 2024, compared with the fifth with the smallest drop. Association, not cause.

# Idea 2: The side that spent more won more.

I checked every Senate race. Did Democrats swing more in states where they spent more?




**Same swing either way. Spending more didn't seem to matter.**

CLUE TRACKER

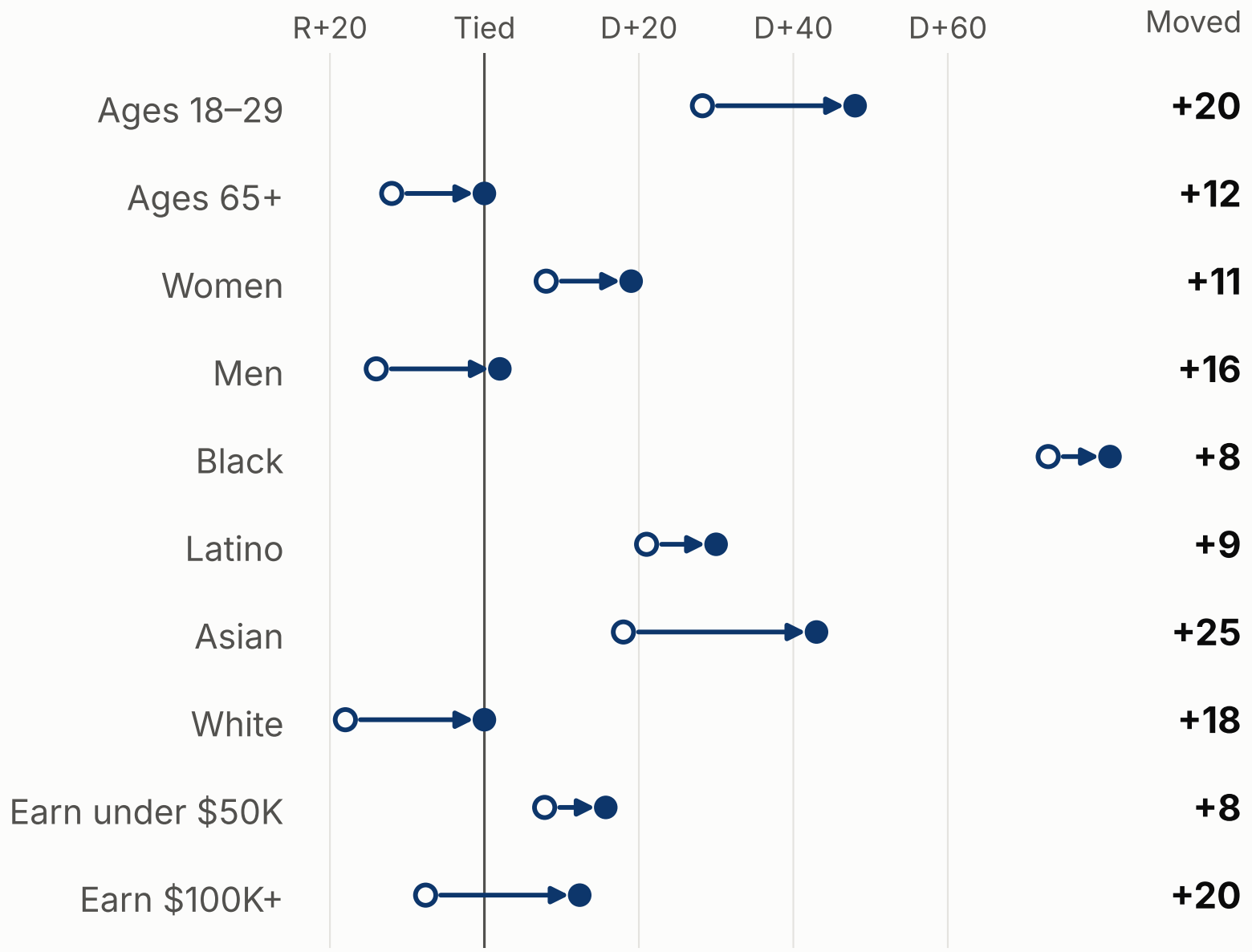
- × **More people voting** — Only a small part
- × **More money** — No clear link
- ? **Voters changed** — Not tested yet

32 Senate races with a Democrat and a Republican. Spending = campaigns + outside groups.
Exact averages: 15.0 vs. 15.2. Data: FEC, civicAPI, tonmcg (2024).

# Idea 3: Voters changed. Every group moved.

Compared with the last midterm in 2022, every group below voted more for Democrats in 2026.

○ 2022 ● 2026 D+20 = Democrats won that group by 20 points




CLUE TRACKER

× **More people voting**
Only a small part

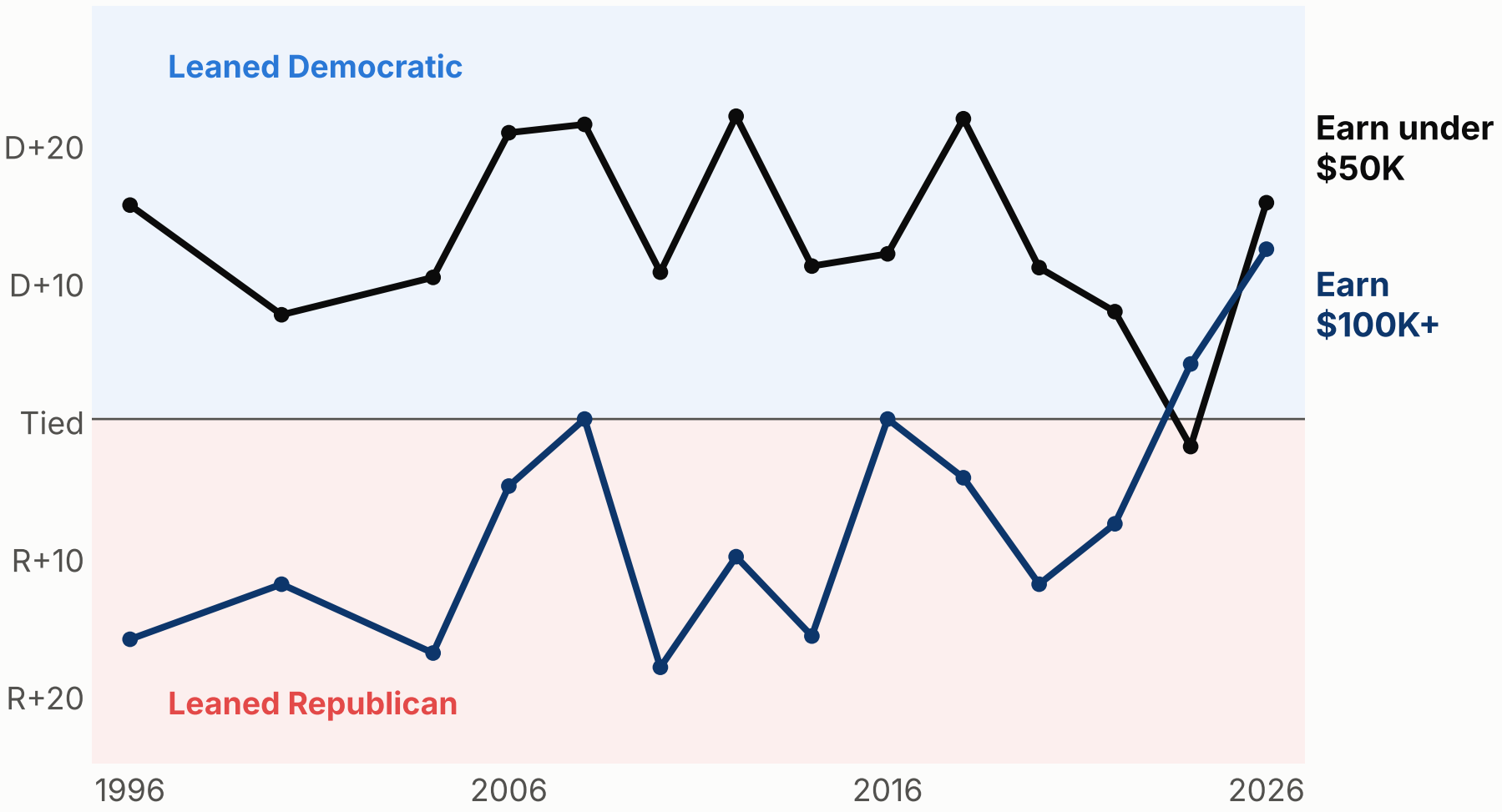
× **More money**
No clear link

✓ **Voters changed**
Biggest clue

National exit polls for the U.S. House. Exit polls are surveys, so each number can be off by a few points. 2026 numbers are early. Data: network exit polls via Wikipedia; checked against ABC News.

# One layer deeper: some changes are older.

For 30 years, richer voters leaned Republican and poorer voters leaned Democratic. Now they vote almost the same.




**The gap between them was 32 points in 1996.**

**In 2026 it was 3.**

CLUE TRACKER

| × More people voting | × More money | ✓ Voters changed |
|---|---|---|
| Only a small part | No clear link | Biggest clue |

Exit polls for president (1996–2024) and U.S. House (midterms). Dollars are not adjusted for inflation.
Data: Roper Center; network exit polls via Wikipedia.

# What I found

✗ **More people voting**

Turnout was high, but it explains only about 1 point of a 15-point swing.

✗ **More money**

States where Democrats spent more swung the same as states where they didn't.

✓ **Voters changed**

Almost every place and every group moved toward Democrats.

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### What the data can't tell us

Why people changed their minds. That needs other data, like polls about the issues. One thing to know: the party in the White House usually loses ground in midterms.

All code and data are free to check:

**github.com/bhrettboggs/midterms-2026-viz**

Results are unofficial and still being counted. Patterns here are links, not proof of cause.